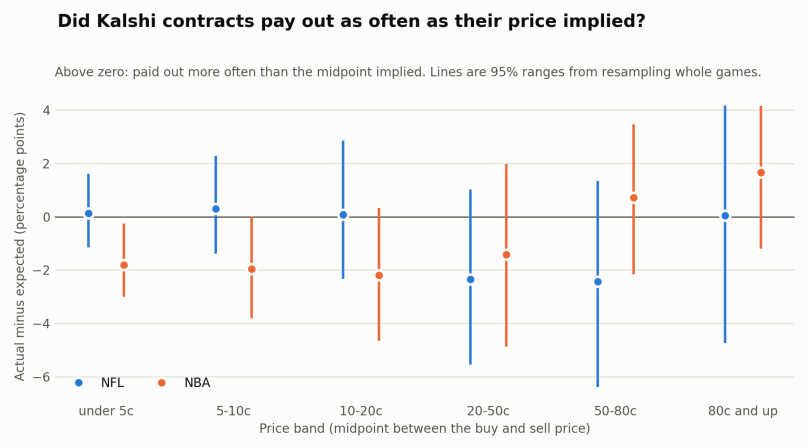
Do Kalshi prices match what happened?

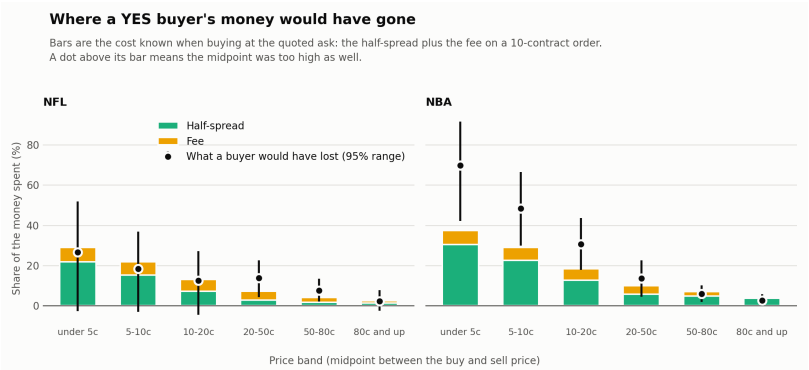
An actual-versus-expected study of 17,653 settled player-prop contracts from 88 NFL and NBA games, 5 October to 9 November 2026. Harrison Hong.

Bottom line. The data shows no measurable gap between Kalshi's prices and outcomes. Measured at the midpoint between the buy and sell price, contracts paid out within a few points of what the price implied, and what a buyer would have lost was mostly the half-spread and the fee. With only 88 games, a gap of up to 4.5 points in a price band cannot be ruled out, so every result is reported with a range.

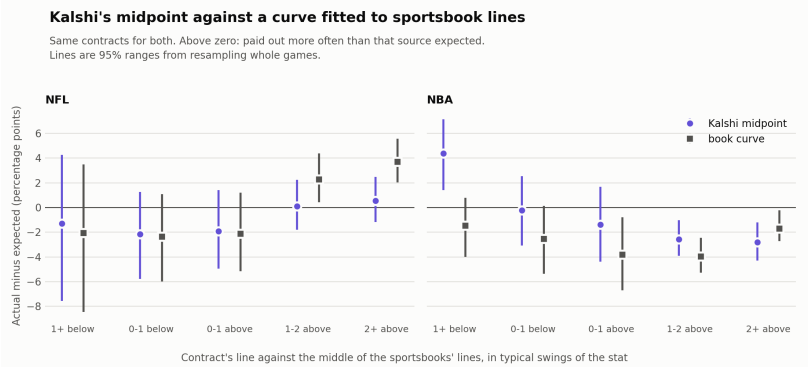
1. No measurable gap between prices and outcomes.
With both leagues together, contracts in every price band paid out within -2.0 to +0.9 points of the midpoint price, and no band's 95% range excludes zero. By league, the exception is NBA contracts under 5 cents: 1.7% paid out against 3.5% expected, on only 7 payouts. Longshot bands are thin: the under-5-cent band has 0.23 of full credibility, or 0.18 once contracts in the same game are allowed to move together. So this is not proof the prices were right: contracts under 5 cents were priced at 3.6% on average, and for the games sampled the 95% range puts their payout rate at 2.1% to 4.3%.



2. What a buyer would have lost was mostly the cost of trading.
Buying YES on every contract at the quoted ask and holding to settlement would have returned -9.9% (-14.2% to -5.9%). Of each dollar spent, 4.4% went to the half-spread, 3.0% to the fee on a 10-contract order, and 2.5% (-1.7% to +6.9%) to the midpoint being too high. The half-spread and fee, both known before buying, were 75% of the loss. Longshots cost the most: under 5 cents the half-spread alone took 24.4% and the return was -39.2%, against -2.5% at 80 cents and up. Dropping any one game leaves the overall return in the range -11.0% to -9.2%.



3. Kalshi and a sportsbook-based curve scored alike, except on rare outcomes.
The two had nearly identical Brier scores: 0.1527 for Kalshi's midpoint and 0.1527 for a curve fitted to sportsbook lines (giving every contract the same chance scores 0.2251), and the range on the difference includes zero. In this sample, on NFL lines far above the sportsbooks' middle, 5.2% paid out; Kalshi said 4.6% and the curve 1.5%. This is exploratory, and it is a finding about this study's own curve, not about sportsbooks.



Method. Prices were logged before each game by my own app from Kalshi's public API; results are Kalshi's settlements. The price bands and return formula were chosen at the first look at the data and other checks came later; nothing was registered in advance. Every 95% range comes from resampling whole games, because one player's contracts in a game win or lose together. The sportsbook curve was set from earlier seasons and not changed during the sample. **Limits.** Five weeks of one season; games I chose to scan; the YES side only; contracts settled part-way are left out. Returns are hypothetical, at quoted prices, with no data on how many contracts were on offer. This is a study of prices, not betting advice. The analysis code is covered by tests.